

Get Indian broadcasters on board with Joost, and in two years, we'll be wondering what we ever did without it

India. More broadcasters will follow, and Joost, unlike so many good ideas, will happen. We're even going to take a leap of faith and say that Joost may eventually feature a user-submitted video channel, or even integrate with YouTube to become the ultimate entertainment platform. Joost's beta program is invitation-only, so you'll have to find a friend who's already using it and sock him/her with an unexpected complement or two.

Get Indian broadcasters on board with Joost, or create our very own Indian version, and in two years, we'll be wondering what we ever did without it.

Beyond

But we're a mobile generation, aren't we? The act of plonking a bunch of MP3s on our phones or PMPs before we set out in the morning is second nature to us. Now picture a world where we get 4G broadband on our cell phones, and combine that with a Joost-ed future. Everything that is

wonderful about Joost on your desktop will move to your laptop, to your cell phone, your Internet tablet (should you be using one at the time), everything.

Concepts like TiVO or Personal Video Recording (PVR) will cease to exist in the context that they do today (viz. pausing live TV). You won't even need to record programs for later viewing, simply because they'll always be there.

There's been lots of talk about India forgoing 3G and going 4G, but given the way we're getting on with 2.5G mobile networks, you can't be blamed for viewing the above as a pipe dream. There is considerable hope in WiMAX, working models of which have already been demonstrated by service providers such as Sify. For more, read about the future of communications elsewhere in this issue.

This vision depends not only on the availability of a good connection, but also on the availability of restriction-free content... ☒

Between Rights And Wrongs

Will we be doomed to a DRM-ed future?

We in India are still quite insulated from it, but soon enough, we'll be touched by the icy hand of Digital Rights Management (DRM) too, and 'twill be a black day for us all. For a while after its introduction, record companies strongly claimed that DRM was in the interests of the artists; now it's taken for granted, and even admitted that DRM is a way to get more money out of consumers.

Rays Of Hope

In his now famous *Thoughts On Music*, Steve Jobs started a chain of thought that no one expected him to—what if the big four record companies were to start selling DRM-free music through iTunes? Knowing that you've purchased music that doesn't impinge on your fair use rights, and will continue to work even after you've gone through seven PC upgrades, five new portable media players, and three different music management programs—it's like the wanton file-sharing we indulge in now, only



Photograph Jiten Gandhi
Imaging Shrikrishna Patkar

legal! EMI tested the waters soon after, announcing that select tracks will be available on iTunes sans DRM and at a superior encoding rate, for an additional \$0.40 (Rs 18), taking the price of a DRM-free song to \$1.29 (Rs 58). The EMI deal isn't exclusive to iTunes, either—in April, Microsoft announced that it will also begin selling DRM-free music on the Zune Marketplace as well. Amazon's also coming up with its own DRM-free music store—featuring, obviously, only EMI music. The proposed price is still pretty high for a song, but that will change if the remaining big three—Sony BMG, Universal and Warner decide to go the DRM-free way too. But will that solve the problem?

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